Chapter Fourteen

First-Generation Land Reforms

India at Independence: A Poor Country with Low Per-Capita Land

The Indian population was 360 million in 1951. That year, net land area sown was a little less than 120 million hectares of a total reporting area of about 305 million hectares. On average, Indians had only 0.85 hectares of land per capita. Compared to any other part of the world, the country had a very small per-capita availability of agricultural land.

More than 82 per cent of Indians (295 million of a total counted population of 357 million in the 1951 Census) lived in rural areas. The Census counted 104 million Indians as self-supporting—those who depended on income generated by themselves. About 70 per cent of self-supporting persons (71 million) derived their income from cultivation of land. Thus, land was the principal source of livelihood for about 75 per cent of Indian households.

In the 1951 Census classification, these 71 million people dependent upon cultivation of land were classified in three categories: ‘owner-cultivators’, ‘unowned-cultivators’ or cultivators cultivating lands of others, and ‘cultivating labourers’. About 46 million (64 per cent) cultivated land wholly or primarily owned by them. These were owner-cultivators. Only 8.8 million (12 per cent) people were cultivating lands that were wholly or primarily owned by others—they were ‘tenant cultivators’. There were 15 million (21 per cent) cultivating labourers. There was one more class of people dependent on land. There were 1.6 million (2.3 per cent) self-supporting persons who depended on the rent incomes from the land. These